The Machine

By Chris Kluwe

INTRODUCTION

What does the future hold for America? Already we are seeing a rise in mega-corporations – Amazon and Google -- run by multi-billionaires. The divide between the haves and have nots is growing and those in power (those with money) seem to care little for the plight of those without. Our homeless population is exploding and if you are Latino – Well, the perception is that you are not welcome here, regardless of your legal status.

We are losing our humanity and will soon be crushed by. . . The Machine, a story by Chris Kluwe

(Scene opens with a pantomime: Marcus shifting on his feet, reaching out to push buttons or twist dials – he's zoned out)

NARRATOR: Marcus stared at the control panel with aching eyes; its hateful collection of flashing lights reduced to nothing more than blurs of meaningless color. He hadn't gotten enough sleep, again, and today was another mandatory sixteen-hour shift.

LUPE: "Marcus? Marcus!"

MARCUS: *(jerking upright)* Yeah, Lupe. I'm here.

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LUPE: Ay Dios mio, I thought you were going to pull a Deion, get an arm torn off. *(she twists dials on her own panel)* You gotta stay awake, Marcus. Those books will be the death of you.

NARRATOR: Lupe twisted a dial on her own panel, taking care not to step out from the barely visible grey-on-grey markings delimiting her safety zone. All around them, mechanical arms, like the severed limbs of some gigantic arachnid, swooped through the air, carrying packages to unknowable destinations.

Heart hammering, now fully awake, Marcus turned back to his own panel, where a flurry of lights demanded his attention. Laboriously, he flipped the switches he'd been not-quite-trained to flip, twisted the dials he still didn't know the meaning of.

MARCUS: *(muttering to himself)* Just make it through. The books are waiting.

NARRATOR: His panel switched over to the pale, pinched face of his supervisor, Brody, glaring out at him.

BRODY: *(Glaring and screaming)* You're falling behind! Do you want this job? Because there are plenty of people who want a job and are willing to work for it!"

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MARCUS: Ye-yes, Mr. Brody, I . . .

BRODY: *(livid)* That's 'Supervisor Brody, you stupid wetback! Just get back to work.

NARRATOR: The screen cut out, leaving Marcus staring at even more flashing lights. Numbly, he resumed putting them out, one at a time. Hours later only two lights remained, the rest having been banished to whatever hell they inhabited between their appearances. He reached for a knob with a leaden arm then nearly swore as the panel switched into fullscreen mode once again. On it, the benign face of an old, bald man stared out.

COMPANY PRESIDENT: Great work, everyone! We here at the Amazon-Wells Fargo-Academi family are fighting hard for your rights in these turbulent times. And to recognize everyone's diligence, I've approved a ten-credit bonus for every worker this month. Don't spend all of it in the company store at once! And finally, don't forget reviews for my new book, 'The Self-Made Man, are due by the end of the week!

NARRATOR: More hours passed, and then *(blaring noise)* -- the end of shift signal. His entire body aching, Marcus shuffled across the factory floor towards the exit.

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Newer faces, not yet battered by years on the factory floor, flowed by in the opposite direction, scrambling to get to their areas on time.

VOICE OVER LOUDSPEAKER: *(Toneless)* Ten seconds until factory operations resume. This is your federally mandated safety warning.

NARRATOR: Marcus and Lupe picked up their pace, now on the verge of running. They reached the exit door as clanging snarls of metal on metal announced the arms lurching into motion once more. A crashing impact joined the cacophony, *(a brief scream)* Lying sprawled halfway across the safety line was a young man, his right arm a mangled ruin. Before they could help him, another mechanical appendage whipped through, slamming the boy's body against the wall with a sodden thump. Blood pooled beneath his unmoving form, slowly spreading across the floor. Marcus hadn't even known the kid's name. A harried-looking woman appeared, her grey suit almost the same shade as her skin, her hands clutching a clipboard.

BETSY from HR: Tsk, tsk *(shaking her head and chewing on her lower lip she holds out her clipboard and speak*

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robotically) Sign here, here, and here.

LUPE: *(a hint of rebellion)* What are we signing?

BETSY from HR: Statements of witness that the company followed standard safety procedures. Abnegation of class-action rights. It's all covered in your contract.

NARRATOR: Two men in hazmat suits were rolling the body into a black plastic bag.

MARCUS: And if we don't?

BETSY from HR: Then you lose your job, we sue you, we pull your citizenship, and we get the government to deport you. Any other questions?

NARRATOR: A blazing fire from the very core of the world bubbled up in Marcus' stomach, a pillar of rage that seemed to have no beginning or end. He clenched his fists, veins standing up along the backs of his hands. Just as it seemed impossible not to throw himself at the woman, he felt Lupe pulling him away. She dragged him out of the factory to the security checkpoint.

LUPE: *(whispering)* You crazy pendejo. You trying to get killed?

MARCUS: *(letting out a long breath and still filled with rage)* They treat us like shit, Lupe. They don't care if we

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die on the floor. What's it matter if they kill me for taking a stand?

LUPE: *(shaking her head)* The difference is, we're still alive. Besides, if you don't have a job, ICE is gonna come for you.

MARCUS: *(shrugging)* ICE is gonna come for us anyway. Having a job, being a citizen, that don't matter anymore. We're the wrong color, Lupe. Nothing we can do to change that.

LUPE: *(Scowling)* You read too much. Still, though. We got a job.

MARCUS: Doing what, Lupe? They ain't teaching us anything they couldn't teach a rabbit. 'Here's a red light, twist the green dial.' 'Here's a blue light, flip the orange switch.' How are we supposed to be anything more than cogs in their machine? *(yawning)* Only another mile to the bus stop.

NARRATOR: They continued on in silence. The chirp of crickets gained ground in their battle against the incessant flow of the freeway as rush hour died away. Then the sound of tires crunching on gravel came from behind, and a bright light.

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ICE OFFICER 1: Freeze! Don't move! Hands where we can see them! Turn around! On your knees!

NARRATOR: The two complied in tense silence, squinting against the spotlight's harsh glare. Making exaggerated, deliberate movements, they raised their arms and clasped their hands over their heads; a familiar position.

LUPE: *(whispering)* *Pinche* ICE. Be cool.

NARRATOR: The two men approached with their hands on holstered pistols. Mirrored sunglasses hid their eyes, despite the late hour.

ICE OFFICER 2: *(caressing the butt of his gun)* What are you two doing out here? Not looking for trouble, are we?

LUPE: *(meekly, keeping her eyes down)* We're just heading home from work, sir. Our bus stop isn't very far.

ICE OFFICER 1: *(laughing)* You hear that, George? Taking the bus. Like we haven't heard that before. Let's see some ID. Slowly now.

NARRATOR: Marcus reached into his pocket and drew forth a laminated strip of state-mandated identification. The agent scowled at it, then tossed it into the dirt at Marcus' knees.

LUPE: *(patting her pockets slowly at first, then with*

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increasing desperation) I-I must have left it at the factory. Por favor, if we can just go ba . . .

ICE OFFICER 2: *(mocking in a singsong voice)* Por favor, por favor. Looks like we bagged us another illegal, Jim.

MARCUS: *(angrily)* She's an American citizen. Just like you and me!

NARRATOR: The agent stepped closer, then lashed out with his fist. Marcus found himself on his back, pain blossoming in his jaw and with the taste of copper in his mouth.

ICE OFFICER 1: *(Snarling)* Without papers, she's whatever we say she is. And right now, I say she's an illegal. What you gonna do about it, amigo? *(unholstering his gun)* Think you' re some sort of hero, amigo? Think you can outrun a bullet?

ICE OFFICER 2: *(Dragging Lupe to her feet)* C'mon, George, let's roll. We got one, no need to be greedy.

LUPE: *(softly crying)* P-please, sir, I have children, they need me . . .

ICE OFFICER 2: *(Screaming in her face)* I don't give a shit about your worthless kids! Shut up and get in the car!

NARRATOR: He dragged her towards the patrol-car

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mounted spotlight, throwing her into the back seat.

ICE OFFICER 1: See you around, amigo. Gonna be your turn soon.

NARRATOR: And then Lupe was gone, a pair of ruby tail-lights disappearing into the unknown. Feeling numb, Marcus staggered to his feet. A car rolled by. Inside, the smiling faces of a family -- all dressed in their Sunday best, singing a popular evangelical hymn, their pale cheeks glowing rosy red. They didn't give Marcus even a glance.

Shoulders slumped and head bowed, he continued towards the bus stop. The books were waiting. If he cut another hour off his sleep, he'd have time to get through the chapter on C4 tonight.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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